



COACH MURRAY · FREE RESOURCE

The 5-Day Cutting Blueprint.

The exact 5-day protocol I use with my own clients to drop fat without losing strength, energy, or muscle.

5

DAYS

3

MACRO TARGETS

0

GUESSWORK

Jonathon Murray

NPC COMPETITOR · ONLINE COACH · FOUNDER, COACH MURRAY

V1.0 / 2026

Why most cuts **stall in week 2** — and how this protocol fixes it.

If you've ever started a cut, dropped a few pounds in week one, then watched the scale freeze for the next three weeks — this guide is for you.

Most cuts fail for one of three reasons:

1. **Calories were never accurate to start.** "1,800 calories" sounds reasonable until you realize your maintenance is 2,400 and you cut by 25% before your body had time to adapt.
2. **Protein wasn't high enough to protect muscle.** So you lost weight — but a chunk of it was the muscle you spent two years building.
3. **There was no adjustment loop.** The plan was set in stone and never updated as the data came in.

This 5-day blueprint fixes all three. By the end of day 5, you'll know your exact starting calories, the floor protein number for your bodyweight, and the simple weekly adjustment rule that keeps fat coming off without crashing your metabolism.

READ THIS FIRST

This is a **5-day setup**, not a 5-day diet. The point is to build a plan you can run for 8–16 weeks. Don't skip days. Don't combine days. The order matters.

DAY 1 · THE FOUNDATION

Find your real maintenance.

Before you cut a single calorie, you have to know what you're cutting from.

The biggest mistake people make is using a generic TDEE calculator, getting a number, and immediately subtracting 500 calories from it. The calculator is an estimate based on the population average. *You are not the average.*

Today, you do two things:

1. Calculate your starting estimate.

Use the Mifflin-St Jeor formula, then multiply by an activity factor:

MAINTENANCE ESTIMATE

BMR (men) = $10 \times \text{weight}(\text{kg}) + 6.25 \times \text{height}(\text{cm}) - 5 \times \text{age} + 5$

BMR (women) = $10 \times \text{weight}(\text{kg}) + 6.25 \times \text{height}(\text{cm}) - 5 \times \text{age} - 161$

Maintenance = BMR × Activity Factor

ACTIVITY LEVEL	MULTIPLIER
Desk job, no gym	1.2
Light gym (1–2x/wk)	1.375
Moderate (3–4x/wk)	1.55
High (5–6x/wk + cardio)	1.725
Athlete / labor job	1.9

2. Eat at maintenance for 4–7 days.

This is what almost no one does — and it's the single most important step. Eat at your calculated maintenance, weigh yourself daily, average the week, and confirm your weight is stable.

WHY THIS MATTERS

If your weight drops eating "maintenance" — your real maintenance is higher than the calculator says, and you can cut more aggressively. If your weight goes up — your maintenance is lower, and a 500-calorie cut would tank your energy. **You cannot plan a cut on a guess.**

DAY 2 · THE PROTEIN RULE

Lock in your floor protein number.

This is the one number you do not adjust during a cut.

Protein is not negotiable in a cut. It's the variable that determines whether you lose 90% fat / 10% muscle, or 60% fat / 40% muscle.

The protein target I use:

DAILY PROTEIN TARGET

Lean / sub-15% BF: 1.0 g per lb of bodyweight

Average / 15-25% BF: 0.9 g per lb of bodyweight

Higher BF / 25%+: 1.0 g per lb of *goal* bodyweight

Example: A 200 lb man at ~18% body fat targets **180 g of protein per day**. That number stays constant for the entire cut, even as bodyweight drops.

The 4-meal protein structure.

Spread your protein across 4 meals, ~40–50g each. Why 4? Higher protein meals trigger better muscle protein synthesis than the same total protein crammed into 2 meals.

MEAL	PROTEIN GOAL	EXAMPLE SOURCE
Breakfast	40–50g	4 whole eggs + 4oz lean turkey
Lunch	40–50g	6oz chicken breast + Greek yogurt
Pre/Post Workout	40–50g	Whey shake + cottage cheese
Dinner	40–50g	8oz lean steak or sirloin

⚠ DON'T UNDERSHOOT HERE

If you're miss your protein target by 20–30g/day for weeks, you'll lose muscle. Set this number first, build everything else around it.

DAY 3 · THE CUT MATH

Set your starting deficit.

The math is simple. Most people just get the size of the cut wrong.

You have your maintenance (Day 1) and your protein floor (Day 2). Now subtract a deficit.

The deficit ranges I use:

GOAL	DEFICIT	EXPECTED LOSS
Slow & sustainable	10–15% below maintenance	0.5 lb / week
Standard cut	15–20% below maintenance	0.75–1 lb / week
Aggressive (short-term)	20–25% below maintenance	1–1.5 lb / week

Pick **standard cut** unless you have a hard deadline. Aggressive cuts work but increase muscle-loss risk and burnout.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Maintenance: **2,400 cal**

Deficit (-18%): **-432 cal**

Daily target: **1,968 cal** (round to 1,950)

Protein (200 lb @ 0.9g/lb): **180g (720 cal)**

Fats (target 25% of total cals): **54g (486 cal)**

Carbs (remainder): **186g (744 cal)**

THE 25% FAT FLOOR

Don't drop fats below 20% of total calories — it tanks hormones (testosterone in men, cycle disruption in women). The right knob to turn during a cut is *carbs*, not fat.

DAY 4 • THE ADJUSTMENT RULE

How to update the plan weekly.

A static plan loses its edge in 3 weeks. The plan must adjust as you do.

This is what 95% of self-coached cuts get wrong. They set the plan on day one and run it unchanged for 12 weeks. By week 3, the deficit has shrunk (because you weigh less), progress stalls, and frustration kicks in.

The Sunday Review.

Every Sunday morning, do this for 5 minutes:

1. Average your last 7 morning weigh-ins.
2. Compare to last week's 7-day average.
3. Apply the rule below.

7-DAY AVG CHANGE	ACTION
Lost >1.5 lb	Add 100 cal (carbs). Cutting too fast.
Lost 0.5–1.5 lb	Hold. Plan is working.
Lost <0.5 lb (or stalled)	Subtract 100 cal (carbs) <i>or</i> add 1,000 steps/day
Gained weight	Subtract 200 cal (carbs) + check adherence honestly

PICK ONE LEVER

When you stall, change **only one variable** — calories *or* cardio, not both. If you cut 100 cal AND add 30 minutes of cardio in the same week, and the next week you progress, you don't know which lever did the work. You've burned a tool you can't replace.

Weekly weighing protocol.

- Same time every morning (right after the bathroom, before water/food).
- Same scale.

- Minimal clothing.
- Log every day. The 7-day average is what matters — not the daily number.

DAY 5 · THE MENTAL GAME

Build the structure that survives week 6.

Anyone can diet for 2 weeks. The system is what gets you across the finish line.

The first two weeks of any cut are easy. Motivation is high, the scale is dropping, and the novelty carries you. Week 3–6 is where everyone breaks. Hunger gets real. The scale slows. Life happens.

Build these 4 systems before you start.

1. The non-negotiable meal.

One meal per day that *never* changes regardless of how the day goes. For most clients, this is breakfast — same protein, same carb, same fat, every single morning. It removes one decision and locks in 30%+ of your daily calories without effort.

2. The 80/20 rule of food choice.

80% of your calories come from a rotation of 6–8 staple whole foods you actually like. 20% can be flexible. This eliminates "what do I eat tonight" decision fatigue, which is the #1 driver of off-plan eating.

3. The Friday recommit.

Most diets die on Friday night, not Tuesday afternoon. On Friday morning, write down: *What's my plan for tonight, Saturday, and Sunday?* Pre-decide. The mental work happens 8 hours before the moment of choice — not in the moment.

4. The 7-day photo.

Once a week, same lighting, same time of day, same pose, take a photo. The scale lies for 4–7 day stretches. The mirror lies because you see yourself daily. The weekly side-by-side photo is the only honest progress mirror you have.

THE REAL WIN

If you do this right, by week 4 the entire process feels boring. **Boring is the goal.** Excitement means novelty, and novelty doesn't last 12 weeks. Build a system that's so dialed it doesn't require willpower.

READY TO STOP GUESSING?

You just got the framework. Want the **full plan**?

This blueprint gives you the shape of a cut. What it doesn't give you is **your specific numbers** — your maintenance dialed to your real-life adherence, your training program built around your equipment and split, your weekly check-in adjustments based on photos and weight trend.

That's what coaching is for. Take your quiz match and get started today — your plan is generated within 24 hours of your intake.

Get Your Personalized Plan →

→ Re-take the quiz at coach-murray.netlify.app/quiz.html

→ Questions? Email Coach Murray directly